

CLEAR AND PRESENT DANGER

India has become both a target and a recruitment base for organisations like Al Qaeda

Much before the Bangalore boys got India its first date with infamy, Al Qaeda managed to spread its tentacles in India, riding piggyback on smaller groups like Jaish-e-Mohammed and LeT, operating from Pakistan. Al Qaeda, Arabic for 'the base', is scouting for new 'recruitment bases' and India is high on the list. Analysts say it is now focusing on recruiting Indian professionals as part of its strategy of assembling cadres

from countries less likely to attract the suspicion of global security agencies.

Intelligence inputs point to the existence of thousands of Al Qaeda sleeper cells in India, with the focus being the penetration of the country's scientific and research institutes. Sources say, however, that not much effort has gone into investigating this aspect. Officials from a Central intelligence agency mounted an investigation around some scientists working in prestigious institutes in south India, suspecting possible links with terror groups, but the probe was shelved midway.

In the last week of June, Jammu & Kashmir Police arrested a person and seized CDs containing Osama bin Laden's messages. The suspect was circulating the CDs, motivating people to take up jihad. The modus operandi of Al Qaeda involves recruiting profes-

sionals without a criminal record to act as sleeper cells. It is now using students and research scholars, converted by religious indoctrination, to fight for the Islamic mission.

Indian security agencies say that in the aftermath of the Mumbai bombings, an Al Qaeda connection had come up, when one of the suspects, Mujaheed Geelani, had pointed to the role of an Al Qaeda leader, Abu Zubaidah, who set up sleeper cells in India before he moved to Pakistan. With pressure mounting on Pakistan, the role of its intelligence agency, ISI, in actively encouraging the recruitment programmes of groups like Al Qaeda, has also come under the scanner. After all, it is good strategy to deflect the pressure by having a new crop of recruits coming from India.

Besides being scouted for possible recruits, India is a target as well. Its

eastern neighbour Bangladesh is fast becoming a breeding ground for Al Qaeda and its allies, with active support from local militant groups like the Harkat-ul-Jihad-Islami (HUJI) and religious fundamentalist parties like the Jamaat. HUJI was established with direct aid from Laden in 1992, and even under the present regime, the country continues to be a potent launchpad for Al Qaeda operatives to travel to India. "Because of its close relations with the US and Israel, Al Qaeda not only looks upon India as a close associate of the US, but also as providing favourable conditions for its overseas operations directed against the US," says security analyst B. Raman.

Even as the Government is worried about Al Qaeda spreading its tentacles, another big concern is the diplomatic fallout. As news of the Indian connection in the London plot spread, a damage control exercise was underway in South Block. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh was on the line with British Prime Minister Gordon Brown, offering help with the investigations and reiterating that it should not lead to random witch-hunting.

It is also a huge setback for the Government's claims that not one person in a country that has the second largest Muslim population in the world is linked to Al Qaeda or to any international terror plot. The Government is keen to take corrective measures, besides sharing information on the suspects and any other intelligence inputs related to the case with the UK and Australian security agencies. Indian envoys have been asked to ensure that Indians do not become victims of hate crimes. However, while the Government braces to handle the diplomatic side of things, the bottomline is that the arrest of Indians in connection with the terror attacks should serve as a warning bell for Delhi to not ignore the clear and present danger.

by Saurabh Shukla

CLICKING ON THE TERROR LINKS



■ Al Qaeda is attempting to infiltrate India's scientific and research facilities and recruit professionals with a clean record as sleeper cells

■ The arrests of Indians in connection with the UK blasts has caused diplomatic embarrassment

THE IISC ATTACK It is suspected that the attack, which was carried out by the Pakistan-based LeT in 2005, also had an Al Qaeda connection